field every second. Logging is carried out for firewood and construction materials, and is also driven by the demand for roads, settlements, and agriculture.

Globally, the rainforests that are under greatest threat are in West Africa, Central America, and Southeast Asia. Indeed, only about 30 percent of the lowland rainforest in Borneo now survives. In the Amazon Basin, home to nearly one-third of the world's rainforest, much of the clearance is for agriculture, especially ranching.

Once deforestation starts, the problem quickly gets worse. When rain falls on a forested slope, it is mostly absorbed by vegetation. But when the slope is cleared, the rainfall erodes the soil, making it useless for agriculture and impossible to replant. It produces silt runoff into rivers and lakes, killing fish, and increases the risk of flooding. The destruction of any forest reduces its capacity to absorb the greenhouse gas carbon dioxide, thereby contributing to the acceleration of climate change.